weight on top of me, I unclutch the ball, leaving it easier for them to dispossess me, and promise myself I will never play this stupid game again.

All of these heroes and attributes and sports begin to stack up in my mind. I am collating them as I go, throwing myself into them, trying to fit them and make them fit me. I can play basketball, adding Magic Johnson to the hero collection from ‘NBA Jam’ on the Game Boy, finding sweet relief in inhabiting his body and inverting my physical lack of height inside the handheld computer game. I can swim. Golf will get me soon. Football really fills up Burnley, the same way it does the rest of the country. One year, my team goes away on a trip to France to play a seven-a-side tournament. I find a way to try and contribute in as many ways as I can, to read the game as intensely as possible, to be as versatile as physically achievable for the team. I am small and not as eye-catching as others, but I make it work for me. In the tournament, a window of play opens where I receive the ball and, cut inside, beat a player, evading their tackle and feel myself suddenly instilled with an outcome that feels pre-destined. From outside the area, I put my laces through the ball and it torpedoes into the top corner. It looks like one of Eric Bristow’s darts. I feel myself swell with a sensation of having done something more than I knew I was capable of. As my teammates surround me, chasing after me, I do not make even one single gesture of celebration. I just jog back to my place. I don’t think I even smile. When we lost the same tournament on penalties, I felt like I had experienced something as brutal as first heartbreak. These two things – the sensation of occasionally awakening a dormant other-worldliness and the absolute distaste for losing – will never dislodge themselves as unmovable, strange curiosities that are a part of being me.